what you see: candidates have not exactly been falling over each other in eagerness. So, the Congress has been forced to scale back on its initial plan to field a few heavies from Sidda's cabinet to kayo the field. Instead, the party has nominated the children of as many as six ministers: Priyanka Jarkiholi, Mrunal Ravindra Hebbalkar, Samyuktha Patil, Sagar Khandre, Sunil Bose and Sowmya Reddy—except the last named, a former MLA from Bengaluru, all rookies. Besides inviting hearty derision from the BJP for being a 'mummy papa' party that's afraid of losing, this is strategy slimmed down to hope: that the ministers will have (s)kin in the game and so won't fully dodge the draft. ■



▶ MADHYA PRADESH

COUPLE OF ISSUES

Alliance-making is tricky enough at the party level. But the upcoming Lok Sabha polls have left no room for informal adjustments even at home for a political family in Balaghat, Madhya Pradesh. Former MP **Kankar Munjare** has asked his wife, Balaghat Congress MLA **Anubha Munjare**, to 'leave' the house till polling day, failing which he'd leave. Kankar, who's fighting as the BSP candidate, says they may be accused of a secret pact if they live under the same roof! Kankar had contested the 2023 state polls from neighbouring Paraswada for the Gondwana Gantantra Party while Anubha fought and won from Balaghat, but he did not make this demand then. Multi-polar political families aren't uncommon—so the MLA-wife isn't very amused. ■





ANI

▶ ANDHRA PRADESH

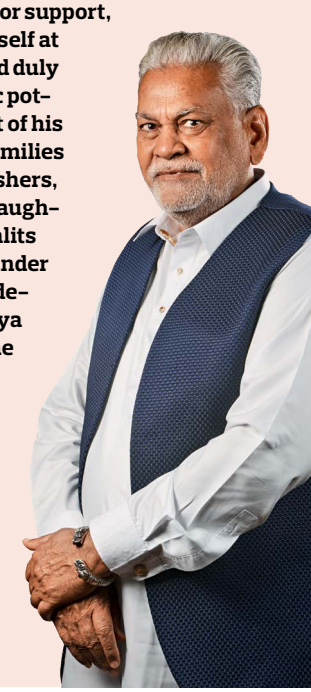
Food for Thought

As a vote-getting device, free rations are a common item on political menus these days. But Telugu Desam Party supremo **N. Chandrababu Naidu**, desperate for a comeback, is trying the opposite trick. He's appealing to the women of Andhra Pradesh to cut off the food supply for their menfolk at home if they don't vote TDP! ■

▶ GUJARAT

RUPALA GETS TOO RADICAL

Union minister **Parshottam Rupala**'s egalitarian turn has boomeranged on him. Trawling his Rajkot constituency for support, the BJP leader found himself at a Valmiki community and duly drew up a bit of eulogistic potted history for the benefit of his audience. The old royal families had cosied up to the Britishers, and even married their daughters to them, while the Dalits never succumbed even under colonial persecution, he declaimed grandly. Kshatriya communities took no time taking offence and, before you knew it, the tall Patidar's effigies were being burnt all over Saurashtra. Multiple apologies from Rupala, on video and in public, have been in vain. The protesters want nothing less than a new candidate. ■



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Ajay Sukumaran, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Jumana Shah, Rahul Noronha, Amarnath K. Menon, Rohit Parihar and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar